

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 955

By Pody

A RESOLUTION to recognize and honor Debbie Stephens for her years of dedicated service to the General Assembly.

WHEREAS, it is appropriate that the members of this General Assembly should pay special tribute to those estimable legislative employees whose commitment to excellence and dedication to public service have brought untold benefits to the citizens of the State of Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, one such individual is Debbie Stephens, who has served as a legislative assistant since 2011, when she brought her singular ability and characteristic grace and charm to Capitol Hill, and she is beloved by her colleagues and legislators alike; and

WHEREAS, a native of Wilson County, Ms. Stephens is the daughter of Robert and Lois Kerr; she was born on Edwards Air Force Base in California, where her father was stationed at the time, and grew up in Watertown, attending school in a three-room schoolhouse in Shop Springs for the first eight years of her educational career; and

WHEREAS, a 1971 graduate of Lebanon High School, Debbie Stephens received her diploma from Victory Bible Training Center in Nashville, focusing on Bible ministry, and began her career as an assistant to the comptroller of Jarman Shoe Company, ultimately retiring from Genesco, Inc., after nearly twenty-five years; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Stephens first came on board with the General Assembly to serve as a legislative assistant to then-Representative Mark Pody, moving with him to the Senate after his election to that body in 2018; in January 2025, she joined Senator Dawn White, chairman of the Senate Education Committee, as her legislative assistant, in which role she continues to serve today; and

WHEREAS, Debbie Stephens has been an invaluable asset to the legislators she has served and to the General Assembly as a whole; as an assistant, she is capable, dependable, and hardworking, and as a colleague, she is a blessing to all who are fortunate to know her; and

WHEREAS, apart from her service with the State, Ms. Stephens has an array of passionate pursuits, all of which she excels in; as a hunter, she has bagged a 5X5 elk in Colorado, and her fishing prowess was evidenced by her forty-pound King Mackerel catch off the coast of Florida; and

WHEREAS, she is the reigning Ms. Wilson County Senior Tennessee, having won the talent, interview, and evening gown components of the competition, and she will represent Wilson County in statewide competition in April 2026 in Crossville; and

WHEREAS, devoted to serving her community, Debbie Stephens is the pianist and treasurer at Cornerstone Baptist Church, is a member and past president of the Watertown Chamber of Commerce, and is currently a member of the Lebanon/Wilson Chamber of Commerce; she was also active in raising public awareness about Jake's Blessing Box, which serves individuals in need; and

WHEREAS, for sixteen years, she has served on the Board of Directors for Wilson County Promotions, where she chairs four committees for the Wilson County/Tennessee State Fair; and

WHEREAS, Debbie Stephens is also a small business owner; she has operated Depot Junction Café, Inc., in her hometown for thirty-three years, serving all the locals and the passengers on the Tennessee Central Passenger train that travels fourteen times per year from Nashville. Her customers have traveled from many bordering states and at least four countries to dine in her establishment, where she works every Saturday and Sunday, welcoming patrons with hometown cooking; and

WHEREAS, throughout her many adventures in life, she enjoyed the love of her husband, James Stephens, whom she married in 1972; the couple enjoyed fifty-two years of wedded companionship until his passing in November 2024; and

WHEREAS, she has also been blessed with the love of her daughter, Kelly (Chad) Boles; three grandchildren, Kaitlyn, Davin, and Abby; one great-grandson, Declan Oliver James Trusty; and fiancé, Tony Watson; and

WHEREAS, Debbie Stephens is an exemplary citizen who epitomizes the ideal of the consummate professional, dedicated public servant, and reliable friend and neighbor; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Stephens has distinguished herself as a public servant of the highest order and is clearly deserving of our respect, admiration, and commendation; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we recognize and honor Debbie Stephens, extending our deepest appreciation for her meritorious service to the State of Tennessee and the General Assembly.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.